EG MENA Crisis, Saudi Arabia, Yemen, Iran QUICKTAKE: Houthis likely to launch limited attacks to extract Saudi payoffs

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MENA Crisis, Saudi Arabia, Yemen, Iran QuickTake

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What happened:

The Houthis have announced that they are imposing a maritime blockade on Saudi Arabia.

Our take:

Houthis likely to launch limited attacks to extract Saudi payoffs without major energy disruption. The group's leader, Abdul Malek al Houthi may signal escalation or de-escalation in a speech on Thursday, with military action potentially following soon after. The Houthis are using threats on Saudi shipping to extract financial support from Riyadh to pay public sector workers in Houthi-controlled areas. Any spike in attacks on traffic in the Red Sea is likely to remain short-lived, with the Houthis hoping to reach a deal with the kingdom after demonstrating a willingness to act.

Saudi Arabia is, similarly, likely to respond before any understanding is reached. Despite its energy vulnerability, Riyadh retains military capacity to launch a counteroffensive, both directly through air strikes (likely backed by the US) and through its Yemeni allies (see: Airport strike raises risk of Houthi actions targeting Saudi energy , 13 July 2026).

The Houthis have so far avoided threatening critical and energy infrastructure. This includes the East-West pipeline and Yanbu port, leaving room for Saudi Arabia to continue exporting oil, perhaps using the more circuitous route through the Suez Canal and the Cape of Good Hope.

Any action will likely be taken in coordination with Iran. Iran would most value Houthi military action that effectively closes the Bab al-Mandeb Strait to all traffic, including Saudi oil exports, such that oil supply is further hindered and prices rise even higher. It is unclear if Tehran is pushing for that, however, not least because it appears wary of overly antagonizing Saudi Arabia, which would be the most affected by Red Sea disruptions.

Houthis likely to reach compromise with Saudis to relax Sanaa International Airport restrictions. The Royal Saudi Air Force conducted strikes on the airport last week to prevent an Iranian government-linked flight from landing. But Riyadh is likely willing to relax other restrictions. Jordan announced on 17 July that it will resume regular flights to Sanaa's airport. The kingdom quickly voiced support, framing it as a humanitarian initiative. The move demonstrates Saudi pragmatism and raises the likelihood of a financial accommodation if the Houthi leader climbs down from maximalist demands, particularly the insistence that the Houthis, rather than the internationally recognized and Saudi-backed government of Yemen, be allowed to control Yemen's airspace. Houthi control would facilitate an airbridge between Iran and Yemen, supplying money and arms to the group–a nonstarter for Riyadh.

Houthi disruptions in the Red Sea will contribute to higher oil prices. Even if Houthi action does not go so far as to shut down the Bab al-Mandeb Strait to oil traffic, Houthi attacks are likely to disrupt some of the flow currently transiting the waterway (4 to 4.5 million barrels per day). Combined with the ongoing closure of the Strait of Hormuz, this will keep oil prices in an elevated band of $90-$110 per barrel for Brent.

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Neutral: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a neutral or negligible impact on the macro business environment

Negative: Political factors in the country are anticipated to have a negative impact on the macro business environment

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